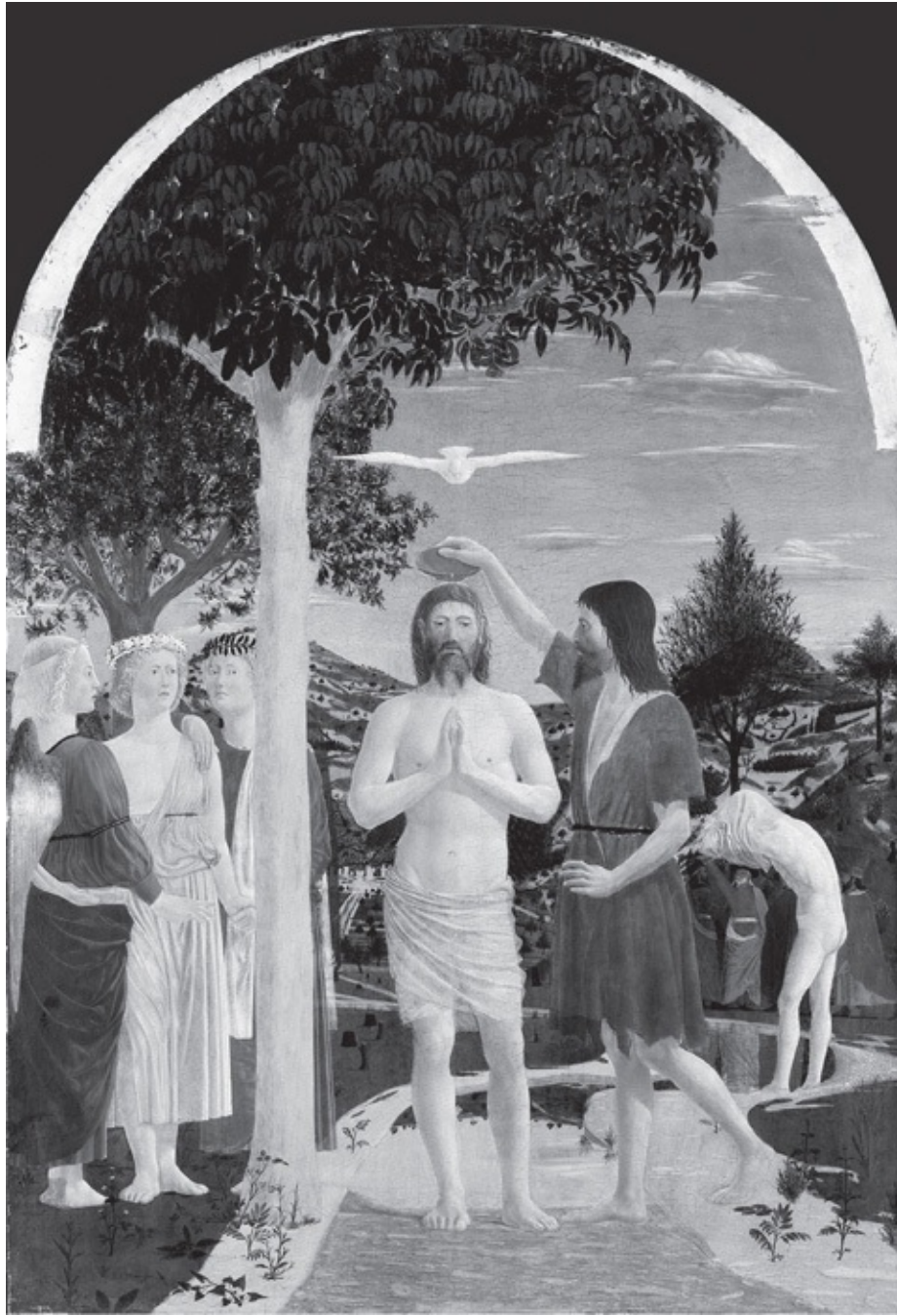


Middle Renaissance

As the 15th century progressed, innovative artists began producing increasingly skilful, lifelike works. The ideas that began in Florence spread across Italy as Florentine artists worked elsewhere and younger artists learned from them. Andrea del Verrocchio (c.1435–88) was the most important sculptor of the period, as well as a goldsmith and painter. His expressive, realistic details became legendary, and his pupils included Leonardo da Vinci and Sandro Botticelli.

Artist and mathematician Piero della Francesca (1419–52) made systematic studies of linear and aerial perspective. His shadows enhance depth and his compositions portray stillness. Andrea Mantegna (c.1431–1506) was also fascinated by perspective, using daring foreshortening with a powerful sculptural approach. His knowledge of Roman art is apparent in his dramatic, heavy-looking figures. Domenico Ghirlandaio (1449–94) was particularly skilful in the portrayal of contemporary figures within religious works. He led a large workshop whose most famous pupil was Michelangelo.



Piero, *The Baptism of Christ*, c.1450s